Madam Rides the Bus

The big idea

Madam Rides the Bus by **Vallikkannan** (translated from Tamil) follows **Valli**, an eight-year-old girl who secretly plans and takes her first bus ride to the nearby town. The joyful trip ends with her first experience of **death**, which makes her grow up a little.

Summary

- **Valli's curiosity:** Valli's favourite pastime is standing in the doorway watching the street. The bus to the town passes her house every hour and fills her with longing to ride it.
- **Careful planning:** She listens to neighbours and passengers to learn the details: the town is about **six miles** away, the fare is **thirty paise** one way, and the trip takes about **forty-five minutes**. She **saves sixty paise** by resisting temptations — peppermints, toys, balloons and a merry-go-round ride.
- **The ride:** One afternoon, while her mother naps (about 1 p.m.), she slips out and boards the bus. The **conductor** jokes and calls her **"Madam"**. She refuses help and acts grown-up, refusing to sit beside an elderly woman whose earlobes have big holes and who chews betel. She stands on the seat to look out at the canal, palm trees, mountains and blue sky.
- **The cow:** A young **cow** runs in front of the bus with its tail high, and Valli laughs and laughs at it.
- **In town:** She does not get off. The conductor offers to buy her a drink, but she politely refuses because she has no money for it. She takes the same bus back, paying another thirty paise.
- **First brush with death:** On the way back she sees the same cow lying **dead** by the roadside, hit by a vehicle. Her joy disappears; she loses all interest in

looking out of the window.

- **Back home:** She reaches home safely. Her mother and aunt are talking about strange things happening in the world; Valli says nothing about her trip, only a hidden remark that shows she has had her own adventure.

Character of Valli

- **Curious and observant** — learns everything about the bus by listening.
- **Determined and disciplined** — saves money patiently for a single goal.
- **Independent and self-respecting** — wants to be treated as an adult, pays her own fare, refuses a free drink.
- **Sensitive** — the dead cow deeply affects her.

GROWING UP

The trip is a **rite of passage**: Valli moves from childish joy (laughing at the cow) to an adult awareness of death (the dead cow). This is the "first brush with death".

WHY SHE REFUSED THE DRINK

She refused not because she disliked the conductor but because she had **no money** and was too self-respecting to accept a treat.

Themes and value points

- Childhood curiosity and the courage to explore.
- Planning, saving and self-control.
- Life and death; the loss of innocence.
- Self-respect and independence.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

How did Valli plan her trip? Why was she called "Madam"? What did she see on the way back and how did it affect her? Describe Valli's character with examples.

Quick recap

- Valli, 8; town six miles away; fare 30 paise each way; saved 60 paise.
- Conductor calls her "Madam"; she stands on the seat to watch the scenery.
- Running cow (laughter) → dead cow (sadness).
- Themes: curiosity, independence, first encounter with death.

Practice questions

1. What was Valli's favourite pastime?

   (a) Playing with friends (b) Standing in the doorway watching the street (c) Reading books (d) Going to the market

2. How much was the one-way bus fare to the town?

   (a) Sixty paise (b) Twenty paise (c) Thirty paise (d) Fifty paise

3. Why did the conductor call Valli "Madam"?

   (a) She was rich (b) She was his relative (c) Teasingly, because she behaved like a grown-up (d) She was a teacher

4. Why did Valli refuse the drink offered by the conductor?

   (a) She had no money and did not want to accept a favour (b) She did not like the conductor (c) She was not thirsty (d) Her mother had forbidden it

5. What did Valli see on her way back that made her sad?

   (a) An accident involving the bus (b) Her mother waiting (c) The young cow lying dead by the road (d) A broken bridge

6. How did Valli save the money for her trip?

   (a) She borrowed from her aunt (b) She worked in a shop (c) She sold her toys (d) She resisted buying peppermints, toys and rides

7. How did the sight of the dead cow change Valli?

8. Describe Valli's character with examples from the story.

Answers: 1. b 2. c 3. c 4. a 5. c 6. d 7. see notes 8. see notes